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CUET UG

History

Social Histories & Mahabharata

Theme 3 · Kinship, Caste and Class (c. 600 BCE – 600 CE) · CUET UG 2027 Complete Mastery

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Syllabus Alignment & Chapter Architecture

Sub-Topic Domain	Official NTA CUET UG Unit III Syllabus Scope	High-Frequency Cognitive Skills Tested
The Critical Edition	V.S. Sukthankar project (1919–1966, 47 years); collation of Sharada, Devanagari, Grantha, Malayalam manuscripts; 13,000 pages; subcontinental core vs regional variations.	Evaluating editorial methodology, textual transmission timelines, and the dichotomy between normative prescription and regional descriptive adaptations.
Kinship & Marriage	Patriliny (**pitrivamsha**) vs matriliny; Kuru lineage conflict; marriage types (endogamy, exogamy, polygyny, polyandry); Manusmriti's 8 forms of marriage; Draupadi's polyandrous union.	Classifying anthropological marriage forms; analyzing Dharmashastric rules of **kanyadana**; evaluating textual debates over polyandry.
Gotra Rules & Satavahanas	Gotra classification c. 1000 BCE; 2 mandatory rules; Satavahana matronymics (Gautamiputra, Vashisthiputra); retention of father's gotra; dynastic endogamy and cross-cousin unions.	Contrasting Brahmanical normative rules with epigraphic records of royal Deccan dynasties; analyzing royal legitimacy vs social customary practices.
Varna & Non-Kshatriya Kings	Purusha Sukta cosmic order; occupational duties; Shastric ideal of Kshatriya rule vs historical reality: Mauryan origins, Shungas/Kanvas (Brahmanas), Shakas (Mlechchhas), Satavahana **Eka Bamhana**.	Evaluating criteria for sovereign political authority; distinguishing between ascribed ritual status and acquired political/military power.
Jatis, Guilds & Beyond Varna	Fixed 4 varnas vs flexible occupational **jatis**; Mandasor inscription of silk weavers (**reshama-vanik**) from Lata; Nishadas (Ekalavya); Mlechchhas; Chandalas; Faxian and Xuanzang accounts.	Interpreting epigraphic evidence of social mobility and corporate philanthropy; analyzing subaltern exclusion and ritual pollution.
Property, Gender & Philosophy	Gendered patrimony; **Stridhana**; Prabhavati Gupta exception; Buddhist rejection of divine varna hierarchy; Majjhima Nikaya (**Mahakachchana** & King Avantiputta); **Mahasammata** social contract theory.	Analyzing women's economic entitlements; contrasting Brahmanical divine kingship with Buddhist consensual, fiscal social contract theories.

CUET HIGH-SCORING INSIGHT & KEY COGNITIVE TRAPS

Theme 3 is one of the most frequently tested chapters in CUET UG History. Focus on these critical distinctions:

1. **Critical Edition Chronology:** Initiated in **1919** under **V.S. Sukthankar** at the Bhandarkar Oriental Research Institute (BORI) in Pune; completed in **1966** (**47 years**), spanning **13,000 pages** in multiple volumes.
2. **Marriage Forms:** Manusmriti outlines 8 forms: Forms 1 to 4 are **Dharmya** (approved/praiseworthy, based on **kanyadana**); Forms 5 to 8 are **Adharmya** (condemned: Asura = bride price, Gandharva = love union, Rakshasa = abduction, Paishacha = intoxicate/deceive).
3. **Satavahana Paradox:** Rulers used **matronymics** (names derived from mothers like Gautami and Vashisthi) and married within the same gotra or kin group (endogamy), yet the system of royal dynastic succession remained strictly **patrilineal** (father to son).
4. **Mandasor Silk Weavers:** Inscription of 5th c. CE records silk weavers migrating from **Lata** (Gujarat) to **Dashapura** (Mandasor, MP). They exhibited occupational diversification (astronomers, warriors, bards) and collectively erected a Sun (**Surya**) temple.
5. **Chinese Pilgrims on Chandalas: Faxian** (5th c. CE) recorded that Chandalas had to strike clappers when entering cities; **Xuanzang** (7th c. CE) noted that executioners and scavengers were forced to live outside city walls.
6. **Buddhist Social Contract: Sutta Pitaka** describes the election of **Mahasammata** ("the great chosen one") to maintain law and order, funded by a voluntary grain levy of $\frac{1}{6}$, disproving the theory that divine right was the only ancient Indian model of kingship.

1. The Critical Edition of the Mahabharata

How do modern historians analyze a colossal Sanskrit epic that developed organically across more than a millennium?

In 1919, under the leadership of the distinguished Sanskrit philologist **V.S. Sukthankar**, an extraordinary team of scholars at the **Bhandarkar Oriental Research Institute (BORI)** in Pune embarked on preparing the Critical Edition of the Mahabharata:

- **Scope of Collation:** The editorial team collected thousands of palm-leaf, birch-bark, and paper manuscripts from across the subcontinent and beyond, written in diverse regional scripts including Sharada (Kashmir), Devanagari, Bengali, Maithili, Odia, Telugu, Grantha, and Malayalam.
- **Rigorous Collation Method:** The team compared verses line by line, selecting only those verses and variant readings that were preserved identically across all regional script traditions.
- **Epic Dimensions & Timeline:** The project required **47 continuous years** of collective labor, reaching completion in **1966**. The finalized Critical Edition spans **13,000 pages** across dozens of volumes, incorporating over **100,000 verses**.

Two Fundamental Historiographical Discoveries

The completion of the Critical Edition completely revolutionized historical understanding of early Indian society:

1. **The Pervasive Subcontinental Core:** Deep structural commonalities were discovered in the central narrative of the Kuru-Pandava conflict, shared across manuscripts collected from the Himalayas to Cape Comorin.
2. **Enormous Regional Variations:** Over half of the 13,000 pages consisted of explanatory footnotes, appendices, and textual variants reflecting regional adaptations. The epic was not a

frozen, monolithic Brahmanical code, but a dynamic, living cultural medium enriched through continuous dialogue between normative Sanskrit traditions and local vernacular folklore.

2. Kinship, Family Structures & Marriage Norms

Social relationships in early India were rooted in the institutions of **kula** (family), **jati** (caste/lineage network), and **vamsha** (lineage descent):

- **Patriliny (**Pitrivamsha**):** Tracing descent, ancestral property, and royal inheritance from father to son, grandson, and so forth. While patriliny had existed in Vedic times, the Mahabharata centralizes it as an urgent moral imperative. The entire epic narrative revolves around a catastrophic war fought between two sets of patrilineal cousins, the Kauravas and the Pandavas, for control over land and the Kuru throne.
- **Matriliny:** Tracing descent and family inheritance through the mother. While exceptionally rare in ancient northern monarchies, matrilineal elements existed in southwestern communities and regional clan customs.

Prescriptive Marriage Types in the Dharmashastras

From c. 500 BCE, Brahmanas codified complex behavioral guidelines in Sanskrit texts known as **Dharmasutras** and **Dharmashastras** (the most influential being the **Manusmriti**, compiled between c. 200 BCE and 200 CE). These texts defined the permissible boundaries of marital alliances:

- **Endogamy:** The practice of marrying within a defined unit, such as one's own kin group, jati, caste, or locality. Common in Southern kinship networks.
- **Exogamy:** The mandatory practice of marrying outside one's kin unit or gotra.
- **Polygyny:** The custom of a man having multiple wives simultaneously. Widely prevalent among ruling Kshatriya aristocrats and elite Brahmanas.
- **Polyandry:** The practice of a woman having multiple husbands concurrently.

The celebrated literary example of polyandry is **Draupadi's marriage to the five Pandava brothers**. When King Drupada of Panchala protested against this unconventional alliance as contrary to the Vedas, Yudhishthira justified it by citing ancestral precedent (such as Jatila of the Gautama clan marrying seven rishis) and asserting that moral duty (**dharma**) was inherently subtle and elusive. Modern historians suggest that while polyandry was uncommon, it may have prevailed among communities in the Himalayan borderlands or during periods of acute warfare and resource scarcity.

Category	Manusmriti Classification	Legal & Moral Significance
Approved (**Dharmya**)	Forms 1 to 4: Brahma, Daiva, Arsha, Prajapatya	Praiseworthy unions centered on **Kanyadana** (the gift of a maiden adorned with gifts, given by the father without receiving any bride-wealth in return).
Condemned (**Adharmya**)	Forms 5 to 8: Asura, Gandharva, Rakshasa, Paishacha	Censured by Brahmanical law: Asura involved commercial purchase of bride; Gandharva was voluntary romantic union; Rakshasa involved abduction; Paishacha involved deception of sleeping or intoxicated woman.

3. The Gotra System & Satavahana Inscriptional Evidence

Around 1000 BCE, Brahmanas instituted the **gotra** system to classify individuals (particularly Brahmanas) into patrilineal descent lineages named after seven revered Vedic rishis (Kashyapa, Atri, Bharadvaja, Gautama, Jamadagni, Vashistha, and Vishvamitra):

- **The Two Primary Gotra Rules:**
  1. **Change of Gotra on Marriage:** A woman was required to surrender her father's gotra upon marriage and formally adopt the gotra of her husband.
  2. **Gotra Exogamy:** Members belonging to the same gotra could not marry each other (**sagotra** prohibition), preventing incestuous lineage unions.



Figure 1: Figure 1 — Kinship, Gender & Authority: Comparative quadrant matrix contrasting orthodox Brahmanical shastric prescriptions against Satavahana epigraphy, polyandry, and the Buddhist social contract.

The Satavahana Epigraphic Contradiction

The **Satavahana dynasty**, which ruled the Deccan from the second century BCE to the second century CE, left extensive stone and cave inscriptions that reveal striking divergences from Brahmanical prescriptions:

- **Matronymics in Royal Inscriptions:** Satavahana monarchs were officially designated by **matronymics**—names derived from their mothers: **Gautamiputra Satakarni** ("son of Gautami"), **Vashisthiputra Pulumayi** ("son of Vashisthi").
- **Retention of Maiden Gotras:** Epigraphic records confirm that royal queens retained the gotras of their fathers (e.g., Gautama and Vashistha) long after marriage, completely disregarding the Shastric rule requiring adoption of the husband's gotra.
- **Dynastic Endogamy & Kin Marriage:** Satavahana rulers married women from the same gotra (**sagotra** unions) and frequently entered into matrimonial alliances with cross-cousins (the daughter of a maternal uncle), a prevalent south Indian kinship practice strongly censured in northern Brahmanical texts.
- **Patrilineal Dynastic Succession:** Despite prominent matrilineal nomenclature, the Satavahana throne was strictly patrilineal, passing directly from father to son.

Normative Prescriptions vs Historical Realities Historians must never confuse normative Sanskrit legal manuals (**Dharmashastras**) with universal empirical realities. While Brahmanical texts prescribed rigid rules, regional kingdoms followed deeply rooted customary traditions that coexisted with, and frequently defied, orthodox social models.

4. The Varna Hierarchy & The Reality of Non-Kshatriya Rulers

The classical Brahmanical social hierarchy was grounded in the **Purusha Sukta** hymn of the Rigveda, which explained the four varnas as emanations from the cosmic sacrifice of the primeval man (**Purusha**):

- **Brahmanas (from the mouth):** Study and teach the Vedas, perform sacrifices, and receive gifts.
- **Kshatriyas (from the arms):** Engage in warfare, protect the populace, administer justice, study the Vedas, and make gifts.
- **Vaishyas (from the thighs):** Engage in agriculture, pastoralism, trade, study the Vedas, and make gifts.
- **Shudras (from the feet):** Perform subservient labor for the three higher varnas (**dvijas** or twice-born).

Historical Dynasties: Who Actually Wielded Sovereign Power?

According to the Shastras, only Kshatriyas possessed the divine right to rule. However, historical and inscriptional records reveal that anyone who commanded military force and economic resources could establish a ruling dynasty:

Ruling Dynasty	Claimed / Textual Origin	Historical & Social Implication
Mauryan Dynasty	Brahmanical texts brand them of "low origin" (**shudra-praya**); Buddhist texts classify them as noble Kshatriyas	Proves that imperial political hegemony rested on personal charismatic leadership and military power rather than pristine birth credentials.
Shunga and Kanva Dynasties	Brahmanas	Successors to the Mauryas were high-caste Brahmanas who seized supreme power through military coups, openly violating the Kshatriya monopoly on kingship.
Shaka Dynasty	Central Asian pastoral invaders (**Mlechchhas** / foreigners)	Considered barbarians by Brahmanas, yet Shaka ruler Rudradaman patronized classical Sanskrit literature and financed the restoration of the Sudarshana Lake.
Satavahana Dynasty	Gautamiputra Satakarni claimed to be **Eka Bamhana** ("peerless Brahmana")	Boasted of destroying the arrogance of Kshatriyas, yet simultaneously entered into diplomatic marriage alliances with the "foreign" Shakas.

5. Jatis, Craft Guilds & Populations Beyond Varna

While the number of **varnas** was eternally fixed at four, there was no numerical ceiling on **jatis**. Whenever Brahmanical theorists encountered occupational communities, craft specialists, or forest

tribes that could not be easily accommodated within the fourfold schema, they designated them as separate jatis:

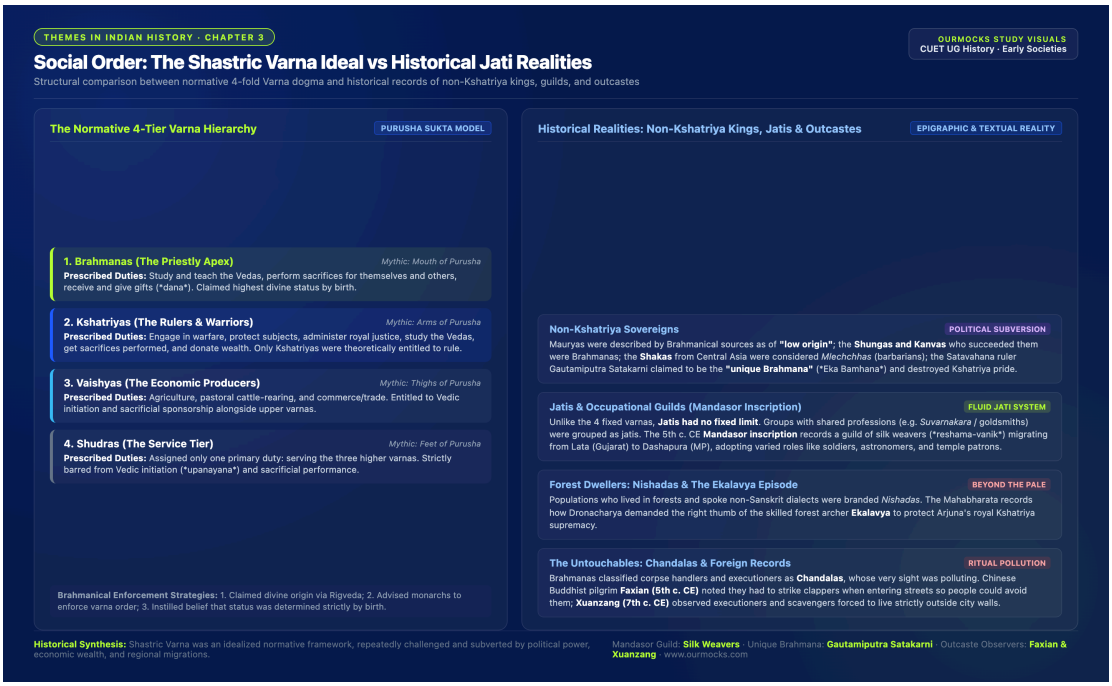


Figure 2: Figure 2 — Social Order: Brahmanical Varna hierarchy contrasted with historical Jati multiplicity, silk-weavers' corporate guild at Mandasor, and marginalized outcaste communities.

The Mandasor Inscription: Silk Weavers' Guild (Shreni)

An invaluable 5th-century CE Sanskrit inscription inscribed on stone at **Mandasor** (ancient Dashapura in western Madhya Pradesh) documents the internal dynamics and social mobility of a guild of silk weavers (**reshama-vanik**):

- **Inter-Regional Migration:** The silk weavers' guild migrated collectively from the region of **Lata** (southern Gujarat) to Dashapura, drawn by the renown of the local monarch.
- **Occupational Fluidity & Diversity:** Although bound by their craft guild, members excelled in diverse callings: some became martial archers, others cultivated astronomy, and some dedicated themselves to religious discourses. The inscription poetically notes that just as a youth is drawn to a beautiful woman adorned with fine jewels, so the region of Dashapura was embellished by this industrious community.
- **Corporate Philanthropy:** Pooling their commercial profits, the guild collectively financed the construction of a magnificent stone temple dedicated to the Sun god (**Surya**), and later undertook its costly restoration when damaged by time.

Populations Marginalized Beyond the Varna Framework

Brahmanical authors categorized communities residing outside the agrarian economy with sharp disdain:

- **Nishadas (Forest Dwellers):** Hunting-gathering forest populations were stigmatized as uncivilized. In the Mahabharata, the tribal Nishada archer **Ekalavya** mastered marksmanship by training before an earthen image of Dronacharya. To protect the Kshatriya prince Arjuna's military supremacy, Drona ruthlessly demanded Ekalavya's right thumb as **gurudakshina**.
- **Mlechchhas:** Nomadic pastoralists and foreign invaders who spoke unfamiliar non-Vedic languages were labeled **Mlechchhas** (barbarians).
- **Chandalas (The Untouchable Underclass):** Positioned at the bottom of the social abyss, Chandalas were considered ritual pollutants. The Manusmriti mandated that they must reside outside villages, use discarded cracked utensils, wear the clothing of dead persons, adorn

themselves with iron ornaments, and serve as executioners of condemned criminals and handlers of unowned corpses.

- **Faxian's Testimony (c. 5th c. CE):** The Chinese Buddhist pilgrim recorded that whenever Chandalas entered a town or marketplace, they had to strike a piece of wood (**talas**) so that citizens could avoid polluting contact.
- **Xuanzang's Account (c. 7th c. CE):** The Chinese scholar noted that scavengers, butchers, and executioners were forced to live exclusively outside city gates in segregated quarters.
- **The Matanga Jataka:** A famous Buddhist tale recounts how the Bodhisatta was born as a Chandala named **Matanga**. When he encountered Dittha Mangalika, a wealthy merchant's daughter, she washed her eyes with perfumed water to purge the impurity of seeing him, provoking her companions to beat him. Matanga staged a non-violent protest by lying at her father's threshold for seven days, eventually forcing her family to consent to their union. Matanga subsequently renounced the world and attained spiritual mastery, illustrating Buddhist rejection of birth-based spiritual hierarchy.

Social Stratification Beyond Varna: The Case of Non-Varna Marriages

The epic preserves vivid accounts of unions that transgressed normative boundaries:

- **Hidimba and Bhima:** When the Pandavas fled into the deep forest following the lac-palace fire at Varanavata, they encountered the maneater rakshasa Hidimba and his sister **Hidimbi**. Hidimbi fell in love with Bhima and proposed marriage. Kunti gave her consent on the pragmatic condition that they live together during the daytime until a child was born. The resulting son was **Ghatotkacha**, who later proved instrumental in the Kurukshetra war. This episode proves that early epic society accommodated inter-cultural unions with indigenous forest groups despite theoretical orthodox bans.

6. Gendered Property Entitlements & The Famous Dilemma of Draupadi

Economic resources were deeply stratified according to gender and social rank in early Indian society:

Patrilineal Inheritance & Women's Property in the Manusmriti

- **Division of Paternal Estate:** Following the death of the father, the family estate was divided among sons, with a special pre-eminent share often allocated to the eldest son.
- **Exclusion of Daughters:** Daughters possessed no legal claim to ancestral immovable property (land or houses).
- **Concept of Stridhana ("Woman's Wealth"):** Gifts given to a bride at the time of her marriage (bridal jewelry, fine garments, and domestic heirlooms) were designated as **Stridhana**. The woman held legal custody over this property, and her children could inherit it without the husband exercising ownership.
- **Prohibition Against Concealment:** The Manusmriti warned women against hoarding family assets or concealing family wealth without their husband's explicit permission.
- **Elite Royal Deviations:** The **Danguna copper-plate inscription** demonstrates that Queen Regent **Prabhavati Gupta** (daughter of Chandragupta II) held independent title to land and donated an entire village to a Brahmana, proving that elite royal women could transcend general legal restrictions.

The Constitutional Crisis in the Gambling Match: Draupadi's Question

One of the most dramatic philosophical debates in the entire Mahabharata centers on the legal question raised by Draupadi in the royal gambling hall of Hastinapura:

- **The Staking of Draupadi:** Yudhishthira, having staked and lost his gold, elephants, chariots, army, kingdom, brothers, and finally his own freedom to Duryodhana and Shakuni, was incited to stake his shared wife Draupadi.
- **The Legal Dilemma:** Dragged into the assembly hall by Duhshasana, Draupadi asked the assembled elders, including the venerable grandsire Bhishma: **"Did the son of Pandu lose himself first, or did he lose me?"**
- **Bhishma's Paralysis:** Bhishma conceded that the nuances of **dharma** were profoundly elusive: on one hand, an unfree man who had lost his own liberty possessed no legal right to stake another person or property; on the other hand, traditional patriarchal law dictated that a wife was always the perpetual dependent and possession of her husband. This dramatic crisis exposed the deep moral contradictions inherent in patriarchal property norms.

7. The Buddhist Critique & The Social Contract Alternative

Buddhism offered a radically distinct critique of social stratification and the foundations of political authority:

Rejection of the Divine Varna Order

Buddhism acknowledged that social inequalities existed in practice, but firmly rejected the doctrine that social hierarchy was divinely ordained or unalterable:

- **The Majjhima Nikaya Discourse:** In an ancient Pali dialogue, King Avantiputta of Madhura questioned the venerable Buddhist monk **Mahakachchana** regarding the Brahmana claim of being the superior caste born from the mouth of Brahma. Kachchana demonstrated that an affluent Shudra possessed the financial power to employ Brahmanas as servants; actual social authority derived from material wealth rather than divine lineage.
- **Universal Egalitarianism of the Sangha:** Upon entering the Buddhist monastic order (**Sangha**), individuals abandoned all worldly caste labels, akin to rivers shedding their individual identities upon emptying into the vast ocean.

The Social Contract Theory of Kingship (Mahasammata)

While Brahmanical texts derived monarchy from divine creation (the king embodying eight guardian deities), the Buddhist canonical text **Sutta Pitaka** formulated a rational, consensual origin of the state:

- **The State of Nature:** In primordial times, human beings lived in harmony, consuming only what nature spontaneously produced.
- **Moral Decay & Emergence of Property:** Over generations, humans became greedy and began hoarding resources. Private property emerged, leading to theft, falsehood, and violent chaos.
- **Election of the Sovereign:** To restore civil peace, the people assembled and chose the most virtuous, capable, and commanding individual to maintain justice and punish criminals.
- **The Fiscal Compact:** The elected leader was titled **Mahasammata** ("the great chosen one") and was remunerated through a voluntary tax of one-sixth of the agrarian produce. This profound early Indian concept established kingship as a human institution based on mutual agreement and fiscal reciprocity.

8. Historiographical Analysis: The Mahabharata as a Historical Source

How do modern historians analyze the layers of the Mahabharata?

- **Language & Register:** The primary text is written in simple, accessible Sanskrit (distinct from the complex Sanskrit of Vedic hymns and royal prashastis), suggesting it was meant to be recited and heard broadly by ordinary audiences.
- **Narrative vs Didactic Layers:**
  - **Narrative Sections:** Contain the dramatic storylines, battles, and character interactions.
  - **Didactic Sections:** Contain formal moral, legal, and philosophical instruction (e.g., the **Bhagavad Gita** and Shanti Parva).
- **Authorship & Composition Chronology:**
  - **Charioteer-Bards** (Sutas)**:** Originally composed oral heroic ballads celebrating warrior chieftains during military campaigns.
  - **Brahmanical Redaction (c. 5th c. BCE):** Brahmanas took over the oral tradition and committed it to writing, incorporating normative varna ethics.
  - **Vaishnava Expansion (c. 200 BCE – 400 CE):** Extensive didactic sections were incorporated, elevating Krishna as a supreme manifestation of Vishnu, expanding the work to **100,000 verses** (**Shatasahasri Samhita**), traditionally attributed to sage **Vyasa**.
- **Gandhari's Appeal and Maternal Counsel:** The epic features profound emotional moments where women offer moral advice to warmongers. In the Udyoga Parva, Queen **Gandhari** pleaded with her son Duryodhana: **"By making peace you honour your father and me, along with your well-wishers... War does not bring good to anyone, nor dharma and artha, nor happiness."** Duryodhana's refusal underscored the tragic consequences of unchecked pride.
- **Archaeological Excavations at Hastinapura:** In 1951–1952, archaeologist **B.B. Lal** excavated the ancient mound of Hastinapura in Meerut district (UP). He identified five distinct occupational strata:
  - **Period II (c. 12th to 7th c. BCE):** Corresponded to the **Painted Grey Ware (PGW)** culture, revealing reed huts with mud plaster (wattle-and-daub), copper objects, terracotta animal figurines, and crude mud-brick structures.
  - **Period III (c. 6th to 3rd c. BCE):** Revealed mud-brick and baked-brick houses, soakage jars, and terracotta ring wells used both as drains and refuse pits, reflecting the secondary urbanization of the early historical era.
  - **Puranic Flooding Confirmation:** The stratigraphic layers revealed evidence of a devastating flood that inundated the settlement at the end of Period II and III, corroborating the Puranic tradition that King Nichakshu abandoned Hastinapura and shifted the Kuru capital to Kaushambi after severe floods.

Social Stratification Beyond Varna: Occupational Flexibility

Classical Sanskrit literature also portrays instances of people pursuing callings outside their ascribed varna duties:

- **Brahmana Merchants:** In Shudraka's celebrated Sanskrit play **Mrichchhakatika** (The Little Clay Cart), the protagonist Charudatta is described as both a Brahmana by birth and a merchant (**Sarthavaha**) by profession, illustrating that rigid Dharmashastric rules were flexibly negotiated in commercial urban centers.

- **Kshatriya Ascetics:** The founders of Jainism and Buddhism, Vardhamana Mahavira and Gautama Buddha, were Kshatriya princes who renounced martial and ruling duties to establish ascetic, egalitarian monastic orders.
- **Royal Donors of Low Varna:** Several regional donor inscriptions from Western Indian rock-cut Buddhist caves record merchants (**gahapatis**), perfumers (**gandhikas**), blacksmiths (**kammaras**), and artisans funding monasteries, demonstrating that non-Kshatriya communities possessed substantial disposable wealth and religious influence.

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Chapter Synthesis & Cognitive Mindmap



Figure 3: Figure 3 — Early Societies & The Mahabharata Topic Summary Mindmap: Complete synthesis of the Critical Edition, kinship, gotra deviations, varna realities, property, and textual historiography.

HIGH-YIELD MEMORY HOOKS & HISTORIOGRAPHICAL POINTERS

- **Critical Edition Numbers: 1919** (start), **1966** (completion), **47 years**, **13,000 pages**, **100,000 verses**, led by **V.S. Sukthankar** at BORI, Pune.
- **Marriage Classifications:** 8 total; 1–4 are **Dharmya** (approved, based on **kanyadana**); 5–8 are **Adharmya** (5: Asura, 6: Gandharva, 7: Rakshasa, 8: Paishacha).
- **Satavahana Inscriptions: Matronymics** used (Gautamiputra, Vashisthiputra); **Paternal gotras retained**; **Endogamous** cross-cousin marriage practiced; yet **throne succession** was strictly **patrilineal**.
- **Non-Kshatriya Kings:** Mauryas (**low birth** in Brahmanical texts, **Kshatriya** in Buddhist texts); Shungas & Kanvas (**Brahmanas**); Shakas (**Mlechchhas**); Satavahanas (**Eka Bamhana**).
- **Mandasor Inscription:** 5th c. CE, silk weavers (**reshama-vanik**) migrated from **Lata** (Gujarat) to **Dashapura** (Mandasor, MP), built a Sun (**Surya**) temple.
- **Chinese Pilgrims on Chandalas: Faxian** (clappers/wood striking); **Xuanzang** (scavengers/executioners segregated outside walls).
- **Buddhist Political Philosophy:** Sutta Pitaka's **Mahasammata** ("the great chosen one") establishes monarchy as a **consensual social contract** funded by a 1/6th grain tax.
- **Hastinapura Excavation:** 1951–1952 by **B.B. Lal**; 5 occupational periods; Period II = **Painted Grey Ware (PGW)** wattle-and-daub; Period III = baked brick & terracotta ring wells.

MASTER STRATEGY CHEATSHEET — SOCIAL HISTORIES & MAHABHARATA

- **Textual Dichotomy:** Never treat prescriptive texts (**Dharmasutras**, **Manusmriti**) as actual social descriptions. Always look for epigraphic counter-evidence (e.g., Satavahana gotra practices, Prabhavati Gupta land grant).
- **Gotra Exogamy vs Endogamy:** Brahmanical rule = strict **exogamy** (marry outside gotra). Satavahana practice = royal **endogamy** (marrying within same gotra / cross-cousins).
- **Varna vs Jati:** Varnas are rigidly fixed at **4** (Brahmana, Kshatriya, Vaishya, Shudra). Jatis are **unlimited** and accommodated occupational guilds, tribes, and foreign immigrants.
- **Stridhana vs Patrimony:** Sons inherited immovable land and cattle (**patrimony**); women could not inherit family land, but retained personal ownership over wedding gifts (**Stridhana**).
- **Authorship Layers:** The core epic was originally composed by **sutas** (charioteer-bards), then written down by **Brahmanas** (c. 5th c. BCE), and expanded with Vaishnava didactic sections (c. 200 BCE – 400 CE) attributed to **Vyasa**.

THE SEVEN FATAL CUET TRAPS

1. **Trap 1 (Duration of Critical Edition):** Confusing 47 years with 25 or 50 years. Project began in **1919** and ended in **1966** (**47 years**).
2. **Trap 2 (Satavahana Matriliny Myth):** Assuming Satavahanas were matrilineal because of matronymics. Royal succession was strictly **patrilineal** (son succeeded father).
3. **Trap 3 (Draupadi's Polyandry Generalization):** Assuming polyandry was the standard practice. It was rare and exceptional; patrilineal exogamy was the Brahmanical norm.
4. **Trap 4 (Ekalavya's Caste):** Stigmatizing Ekalavya as a Shudra. He was a **Nishada** (forest-dwelling hunter-gatherer), outside the varna system entirely.
5. **Trap 5 (Mandasor Guild Identification):** Confusing the Mandasor inscription with ivory carvers of Vidisha. Mandasor relates to **silk weavers** from Lata (Gujarat).
6. **Trap 6 (Buddhist Social Contract Authority):** Attaching divine sanction to Mahasammata. He was chosen by **human consensus** (**social contract**), not divine ordination.
7. **Trap 7 (Hastinapura Archaeologist):** Mixing up B.B. Lal with John Marshall or Alexander Cunningham. **B.B. Lal** excavated Hastinapura in **1951–1952**.

Exam-Style Practice Questions & Detailed Solutions

Part 1: Textual Criticism & Kinship Rules (Q1 to Q5)

Q1. The ambitious project to prepare a Critical Edition of the Mahabharata was initiated in 1919 at the Bhandarkar Oriental Research Institute (BORI) under the leadership of which renowned Sanskrit scholar?

(A) B.B. Lal
(B) V.S. Sukthankar
(C) Alexander Cunningham
(D) James Prinsep

Sol. Q1. Critical Edition Leadership:

- In 1919, the eminent Sanskrit scholar **V.S. Sukthankar** led a team of researchers at the Bhandarkar Oriental Research Institute (BORI) in Pune to prepare the authoritative Critical Edition of the Mahabharata.
- The project took 47 years to collate thousands of regional manuscripts into 13,000 pages.

Therefore, Option B is the correct answer. **Answer: (B)**

Q2. How many years of collective collation and scholarly research were required to bring the Critical Edition of the Mahabharata to its final completion in 1966?

(A) 47 years
(B) 25 years
(C) 35 years
(D) 52 years

Sol. Q2. Collation Timeline:

- The colossal Critical Edition project commenced in 1919 and was completed in 1966, requiring **47 years** of painstaking textual collation across manuscripts written in diverse subcontinental scripts.

Therefore, Option A is the correct answer. **Answer: (A)**

Q3. Which anthropological form of marriage is defined as the practice of a woman having several husbands concurrently, as exemplified in the epic by Draupadi's marriage to the Pandavas?

(A) Polygyny
(B) Endogamy
(C) Exogamy
(D) Polyandry

Sol. Q3. Definition of Polyandry:

- **Polyandry** refers to a marital arrangement where a woman has multiple husbands simultaneously.
- In the Mahabharata, Draupadi's union with the five Pandava brothers is the most famous literary example.

Therefore, Option D is the correct answer. **Answer: (D)**

Q4. According to the Brahmanical gotra regulations codified from c. 1000 BCE onwards, which of the following practices was strictly forbidden?

(A) Adopting the husband's gotra upon marriage
(B) Naming gotras after revered Vedic sages
(C) Marriage between individuals belonging to the same gotra
(D) Women retaining their father's gotra after marriage

Sol. Q4. Brahmanical Gotra Regulations:

- Brahmanical gotra rules laid down two fundamental principles: women were to take their husband's gotra upon marriage, and members of the same gotra could never marry (**sagotra** prohibition).
- Therefore, marriage between individuals of the same gotra was strictly forbidden to enforce exogamy (Option C).

Answer: (C)

Q5. Inscriptional evidence reveals that rulers of the Satavahana dynasty deviated from orthodox Brahmanical marital rules primarily by:

(A) Abolishing all hereditary royal succession
(B) Practicing dynastic endogamy and cross-cousin marriage while retaining maternal gotras
(C) Prohibiting the use of Sanskrit in royal land grant charters
(D) Forcing all queens to adopt Jainism upon marriage

Sol. Q5. Satavahana Gotra Deviations:

- Epigraphic records show Satavahana queens retained their paternal gotras (Gautama and Vashistha) after marriage, and monarchs practiced **endogamy** by marrying within the same gotra or kin group (cross-cousins).

Therefore, Option B accurately identifies their deviation from Shastric norms. **Answer: (B)**

Part 2: Social Stratification, Jatis & Guild Mobility (Q6 to Q10)

Q6. The famous 5th-century CE Sanskrit stone inscription discovered at Mandasor (ancient Dashapura in Madhya Pradesh) documents the collective migration, social diversification, and religious patronage of a guild of:

(A) Silk weavers migrating from the Lata region of Gujarat
(B) Ivory carvers migrating from Vidisha
(C) Bronze metalworkers migrating from Thanjavur
(D) Horse traders from the northwestern frontier

Sol. Q6. Mandasor Inscription:

- The 5th-century CE Mandasor inscription documents a guild of **silk weavers** (**reshama-vanik**) who migrated from **Lata** (Gujarat) to Dashapura (Mandasor, MP).
- They engaged in diverse pursuits (archery, astronomy, religion) and pooled funds to build a magnificent Sun (**Surya**) temple.

Therefore, Option A is the correct answer. **Answer: (A)**

Q7. According to the legal framework of the Manusmriti, which category of marriage forms was considered 'dharmya' (praiseworthy and legally approved)?

(A) The last four forms (Forms 5 to 8)
(B) The first four forms (Forms 1 to 4)
(C) Only the voluntary romantic union known as Gandharva
(D) All eight forms equally without moral distinction

Sol. Q7. Manusmriti Marriage Valuation:

- The Manusmriti outlines eight forms of marriage: the **first four forms** were categorized as **dharmya** (approved/praiseworthy), centered on the gift of a maiden (**kanyadana**).
- Forms 5 to 8 (Asura, Gandharva, Rakshasa, Paishacha) were condemned as adharmya.

Therefore, Option B is the correct answer. **Answer: (B)**

Q8. Which tribal forest dweller (Nishada) in the Mahabharata acquired supreme archery skills by practicing before an earthen image of Dronacharya, only to be forced to surrender his right thumb as gurudakshina?

(A) Ghatotkacha
(B) Vidura
(C) Ekalavya
(D) Sanjaya

Sol. Q8. Ekalavya and Dronacharya:

- **Ekalavya**, a Nishada (forest-dwelling hunter), mastered archery independently. Dronacharya demanded his right thumb as **gurudakshina** to ensure the Kshatriya prince Arjuna remained the undisputed greatest archer.

Therefore, Option C is the correct answer. **Answer: (C)**

Q9. The Chinese Buddhist pilgrim Faxian (5th century CE) recorded that members of which severely marginalized group were required to strike wooden clappers when entering a city?

(A) Chandalas
(B) Brahmanas
(C) Mlechchhas
(D) Vaishyas

Sol. Q9. Faxian on Chandalas:

- The Chinese Buddhist pilgrim **Faxian** recorded that **Chandalas** (deemed ritual pollutants) had to strike a piece of wood upon entering city gates so people could avoid touching or seeing them.

Therefore, Option A is the correct answer. **Answer: (A)**

Q10. Under classical Brahmanical law codified in the Manusmriti, what was the legal status of 'Stridhana' (woman's wealth)?

(A) It was surrendered to the state treasury upon the husband's death
(B) It was divided equally among all surviving brothers of the husband
(C) It was retained by the woman, could be inherited by her children, and the husband had no claim of ownership over it
(D) It could only consist of ancestral immovable landed estates

Sol. Q10. Concept of Stridhana:

- **Stridhana** ("woman's wealth") consisted of gifts (jewelry, clothes) received by a woman at marriage.
- It was legally hers, inherited by her children, and the husband had no legal claim to divide or seize it.

Therefore, Option C is the correct answer. **Answer: (C)**

Part 3: Gender, Property, Buddhist Philosophy & Archaeology (Q11 to Q15)

Q11. In the Buddhist Pali text Sutta Pitaka, what title is bestowed upon the first sovereign leader elected by human consensus to maintain civil order and dispense justice in exchange for a grain tax?

(A) Chakravartin (B) Devaputra
(C) Rajadhiraja (D) Mahasammata

Sol. Q11. The Buddhist Mahasammata Concept:

- In the **Sutta Pitaka**, the first king elected by popular human consensus to punish wickedness and maintain order in exchange for one-sixth of the grain harvest was titled **Mahasammata** ("the great chosen one").

Therefore, Option D is the correct answer. **Answer: (D)**

Q12. Between 1951 and 1952, which prominent Indian archaeologist conducted systematic excavations at the ancient epic mound of Hastinapura in Meerut district, Uttar Pradesh?

(A) B.B. Lal (B) Daya Ram Sahni
(C) R.D. Banerji (D) A. Ghosh

Sol. Q12. Excavations at Hastinapura:

- Archaeologist **B.B. Lal** excavated Hastinapura in 1951–1952, identifying five occupational periods, notably Period II characterized by Painted Grey Ware (PGW).

Therefore, Option A is the correct answer. **Answer: (A)**

Q13. Which Satavahana monarch famously proclaimed himself to be the 'unique Brahmana' (Eka Bamhana) and the destroyer of Kshatriya pride in his mother's Nasik cave inscription?

(A) Simuka (B) Vashisthiputra Pulumayi
(C) Gautamiputra Satakarni (D) Yajna Sri Satakarni

Sol. Q13. Gautamiputra Satakarni:

- **Gautamiputra Satakarni** (2nd c. CE) claimed in the Nasik prashasti of his mother Gautami Balashri to be the **Eka Bamhana** ("peerless Brahmana") and the crusher of Kshatriya pride.

Therefore, Option C is the correct answer. **Answer: (C)**

Q14. The profound dialogue between King Avantiputta of Madhura and the Buddhist sage Mahakachchana in the Majjhima Nikaya was formulated to demonstrate which philosophical thesis?

(A) That spiritual salvation requires the performance of Vedic fire sacrifices (B) That economic wealth and material resources, rather than divine birth, dictate actual social deference and authority
(C) That monarchs must abdicate their crowns and join the Sangha (D) That Kshatriyas are biologically superior to all other human orders

Sol. Q14. Majjhima Nikaya Social Critique:

- Mahakachchana demonstrated that a wealthy Shudra could hire Brahmanas and Kshatriyas as servants, proving that social deference is rooted in **economic wealth** rather than immutable divine birth.

Therefore, Option B is the correct answer. **Answer: (B)**

Q15. Modern textual historians classify the contents of the colossal Mahabharata epic primarily into which two functional analytical categories?

(A) Mythological verses and chronological annals (B) Vedic hymns and secular panegyrics
(C) Ritual mantras and royal administrative genealogies (D) Narrative sections (storylines) and didactic sections (moral, social, and philosophical instructions)

Sol. Q15. Narrative and Didactic Classification:

- Historians divide the Mahabharata into two primary categories:
  1. **Narrative:** Dramatic stories, battles, and episodes.
  2. **Didactic:** Moral, social, legal, and philosophical instruction (such as the Bhagavad Gita).

Therefore, Option D is the correct answer. **Answer: (D)**